PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #39 · DEPRESSION

“My sins are unforgivable.”

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Where it often comes from

A shameful act, a repeated habit, a cruel word, or a religious voice that used guilt as a weapon can convince a person they have crossed a line God will not cross back. Depression turns proper sorrow into a closed case: not “I need forgiveness,” but “forgiveness cannot apply to me.” Sin is real. The lie is that Christ’s forgiveness has a limit you have passed, so confession is useless and God is finished with you. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture takes sin seriously, and it speaks clearly about pardon. “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.” As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions. He pardons iniquity and does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion. There is no condemnation for those in Christ. These words are not permission to take sin lightly. They are God’s answer to the claim that your sin is beyond Him.

> *“If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness”* (1 John 1:9).

Also see

> “As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us” (Psalm 103:12).

> “Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance—who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion?” (Micah 7:18).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

Common self-statements

- God might forgive others, but not this.
- I have asked too many times.
- If people knew, they would agree I am past hope.
- Confession will not reach what I did.
- I have to pay for this myself.
- I should stay away from God so I do not insult Him.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: If this sin was serious, forgiveness is impossible.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unforgivable and calling the feeling God’s decision.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring the promise of cleansing because I do not feel clean.
- Magnification: Making my sin bigger than the cross.

Challenging questions

- What exactly am I calling unforgivable, and who told me God stops there?

- Have I confused the seriousness of sin with a limit on God's mercy?
- What does 1 John 1:9 say God does when we confess?
- Am I trying to pay for what Christ already carried?
- Would I tell a repentant friend that God could not forgive them?
- What would trusting forgiveness look like this week, even before I feel it?

Truth summary

> My sin is real, and it is not beyond God's forgiveness. If I confess it, He is faithful to forgive and cleanse me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

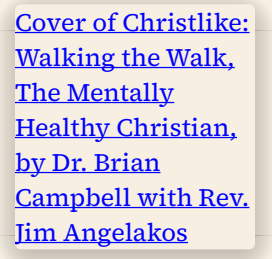
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Love, By God
- Faith
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Sin
- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Depression

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

East to West — Casting Crowns
God removes confessed sin as far as east is from west.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Grace, not self-punishment, breaks the chain.

The Power of the Cross — Keith and Kristyn Getty
Christ's cross answers guilt. You do not have to pay it yourself.

To God Be the Glory — Reawaken Hymns
Redemption and forgiveness are the reason to give God glory.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My sins are unforgivable."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My sins are unforgivable." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly am I calling unforgivable, and who told me God stops there?
- ☐ Have I confused the seriousness of sin with a limit on God's mercy?
- ☐ What does 1 John 1:9 say God does when we confess?
- ☐ Am I trying to pay for what Christ already carried?
- ☐ Would I tell a repentant friend that God could not forgive them?
- ☐ What would trusting forgiveness look like this week, even before I feel it?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My sin is real, and it is not beyond God's forgiveness. If I confess it, He is faithful to forgive and cleanse me.
- ☐ God forgives the sins I confess. He is faithful.
- ☐ Serious sin is not the same thing as unforgivable sin.
- ☐ I do not have to punish myself to finish Christ's work.
- ☐ Feeling guilty is not the same as being unforgiven.
- ☐ God's mercy is larger than my worst act.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 John 1:9
  "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."
- ☐ Psalm 103:12
  "As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us."
- ☐ Micah 7:18
  "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His inheritance— who does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in loving devotion?"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "unforgivable" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when mercy felt out of reach. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 John 1:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I confess this sin, and God is faithful to forgive and cleanse me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio or the Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Confess it in plain words. Write the sin to God in one honest sentence, then read 1 John 1:9 aloud as His answer. Destroy the paper if you need to.
- [ ] Stop the extra sentence. When you confess, do not add "but not me." Stop at God's promise.
- [ ] Tell a pastor or wise believer if the shame is too heavy to carry alone. Ask them to pray the promise with you.
- [ ] Get help if shame includes wanting to die. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988, or tell someone near you today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My sins are unforgivable.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I trusted forgiveness
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My sins are unforgivable~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have sinned, and I have called it beyond You. You are faithful and just. Forgive me, cleanse me, and teach me to come to You instead of hiding. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.